

Coping with the BIG 5

Lifestyle diseases are snuffing out lives and taking away productive years. The future looks menacing as India modernises at blinding speed.

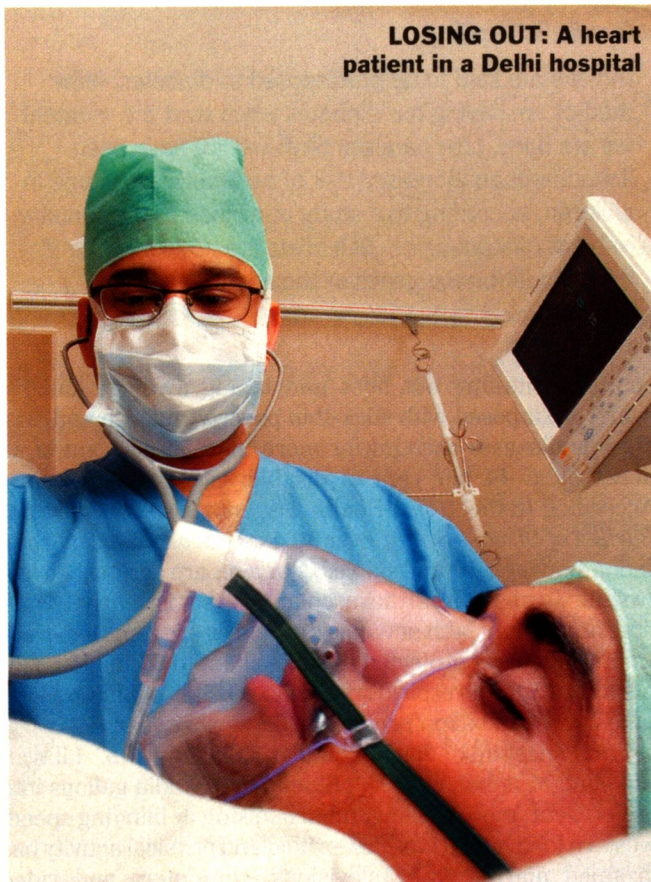
■ By Damayanti Datta

There are many ways to measure the wealth of a nation. Economists count the consumer mantra in today's India: make good money, get cars, get houses, get gadgets, get meals out. Medics add the crucial rider: along with these, get the Big Five—obesity, diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, respiratory problems and cancer. In the surge of globalisation—as modern ways open India's doors to lifestyle excesses—dreaded diseases stalk the expanding middle and upper classes. Chronic diseases stand almost as totems of success in India now.

Tucked away off the upscale Chennai neighbourhood of Anna Nagar, there's a little patch of green. Asiad Colony. A barren sprawl few years back, it's now filled with joggers, at all hours. It all started in 1998 when Dr V. Mohan, the man with a mission against diabetes, started spreading the good word. And 500 neighbours, all in poor shape, resolved to reinvent their lifestyles. Milling in energy and money, they built the dream park, with joggers' lanes, fountains, and even music. Within years, their fitness, blood sugar and cholesterol levels had improved magically. A case study now in the *Journal of Association of Physicians of India*, Asiad Colony created a ripple effect. At least a 100 parks have come up in Chennai with community effort and another 100 have been repaired.

India needs many more Asiad Colonies. For in a hushed but unrelenting manner, lifestyle diseases are engulfing the

LOSING OUT: A heart patient in a Delhi hospital



BANDEEP SINGH

Heart Diseases



- 9.2 million lives were lost in 2000 due to cardiovascular diseases in India.
- 6-fold rise in heart diseases in urban India in four decades.

Floss Teeth, Avoid Heart Attack

No. Scientists are not pulling a fast one. For the first time, medics have linked up gum disease with heart health. The study, published in the *New England Journal of Medicine* this year claims, bacterial infection of the gums is one of the triggers for cardiovascular diseases as it causes inflammatory response throughout the body. Wield the brush religiously.

Respiratory Woes



- Nearly 2 billion sick days were lost in 2005 due to respiratory problems in India.
- 7% of all deaths in 2005 were due to respiratory diseases.

Laugh for Your Lungs

Laughter is the best medicine, they say. For what, if you've wondered, here's the lowdown: new research in the journal *Thorax*, by Harvard pulmonologists show that hostility is a risk factor for poor lung function. Researchers found that those who were more hostile at the outset of the study suffered a more rapid decline in lung function. And the damage is as bad as smoking.